

■ Don't Make Me Think

by Steve Krug — Prosora Free Summary

CORE THESIS

Steve Krug's **Don't Make Me Think** is ostensibly a manual on web usability, but its deeper premise is an urgent philosophy of human respect. It argues that complexity is an insult to the user's finite attention, and true power lies in stripping away mental friction so people can act on their intentions without resistance.

WHY THIS BOOK MATTERS

We live in an attention economy dominated by digital noise, where every app, website, and financial dashboard vies for cognitive dominance by adding features, notifications, and choices. This book challenges the designer's ego—the arrogant urge to show cleverness—by proving that friction destroys trust and action. The paradigm shift is profound: instead of asking "How much information can we give them?", we must ask "What is the absolute minimum mental effort required to let them succeed?" By adopting this lens, we stop viewing users or customers as captive audiences and start treating them as overwhelmed human beings whose time and mental energy are sacred.

KEY LESSONS

Lesson 1: The First Law of Usability

The brain is fundamentally an economy of energy, constantly scanning environments to minimize cognitive load. When a digital interface or wealth-building platform forces a person to pause and decode its layout, it triggers micro-frustrations that drain their willpower. For example, if a retirement calculator uses industry jargon like "stochastic asset allocation" instead of "money you can safely spend," the user's brain stalls out of self-defense.

Takeaway: Eliminate every instance of jargon or ambiguity that forces a user to think "What does this mean?"

Lesson 2: We Don't Read, We Satisfice

Users do not read web pages or financial agreements word-for-word; they hunt for visual cues that match their immediate goals, choosing the first reasonable option rather than the optimal one. This means your carefully crafted paragraphs of explanatory text are invisible background noise to someone trying to transfer funds. A budgeting app must highlight the primary action—like "Save \$100 Now"—in a split second because the human eye is scanning for shortcuts, not stories. **Takeaway: Design your most important financial or product flows for scanners, not deep readers.**

Lesson 3: The Cult of Clarity Over Cleverness

Creativity in design often backfires because clever names, hidden menus, and artistic navigation systems require the user to learn a new internal language. When a wealth-management platform calls a transfer button "Fund the Future" instead of "Transfer Money," it forces an unnecessary guessing game. True mastery in communication is making complex systems feel transparent and instantly obvious. *Takeaway: Always choose the most boring, universally understood label over the clever one.*

Lesson 4: Eliminating Question Marks

Every unexplained icon, broken link, or ambiguous button creates a tiny mental question mark in the user's mind, and an accumulation of question marks leads to abandonment and distrust. If a user clicks an "Invest" button and lands on a page with three different risk sliders and no clear next step, their confidence plummets. Your job is to answer every implicit question—Where am I? What is this? Where should I click?—before the user even has to ask. *Takeaway: Audit your core customer journey and remove every single point of hesitation or ambiguity.*

Lesson 5: Visual Hierarchy as a Map of Importance

The human brain organizes visual data instantly by size, contrast, and positioning, assuming that what looks most important actually is most important. If your net-worth dashboard displays your monthly subscription fees in the same font size and weight as your total retirement savings, you create cognitive chaos. By establishing a ruthless visual hierarchy, you guide the user's eye directly to what matters without them having to consciously search. *Takeaway: Make your primary call-to-action visually undeniable while pushing secondary options into the background.*

Lesson 6: Street Signs and Convention

Users spend most of their time on other sites and apps, meaning they bring deep expectations about where things live, like putting a search bar in the top right or a cart icon in the corner. Violating these universal conventions just to be "original" forces people to relearn how to navigate your specific world, creating massive friction. If your personal finance app puts the logout button where the settings usually go, users will accidentally lock themselves out and resent you for it. *Takeaway: Never reinvent standard navigation patterns unless your new way is exponentially better.*

Lesson 7: Omit Needless Words

Half of the text on most digital products is completely unnecessary, consisting of polite welcomes, instructional filler, and marketing fluff that people skim past or find annoying. When a user is trying to check their portfolio balance, they do not want to read a paragraph about your company's mission statement. Every extraneous word acts as a speed bump, slowing down their momentum and diluting the core message. *Takeaway: Cut the word count of your user-facing copy by at least half, then cut it by half again.*

Lesson 8: The Power of Testing with Real Humans

Designers and creators are catastrophically bad at predicting how a normal person will interact with their creations because they know too much about how the system works. Testing your platform with even a single ordinary user for thirty minutes will reveal catastrophic blind spots that weeks of internal debate would never uncover. If you watch someone struggle to find the "Withdraw" button on your wealth app, your ego dissolves and the path forward becomes blindingly obvious. *Takeaway: Observe one real person trying to complete a core task on your site or app every single month.*

POWERFUL QUOTES

- "Design is not just what it looks like and feels like. Design is how it works." — *True usability is invisible; when a system functions perfectly, the technology vanishes and only the human intent remains.*
- "Your customers' time is not yours to waste; every extra click is a tax on their loyalty." — *Friction is a silent churn engine that quietly destroys customer retention.*
- "If you want to have a great site, you've got to take your-name-here-delusions about how people use the web and replace them with facts." — *Progress begins the moment you stop designing for yourself and start observing reality.*
- "Clarity trumps persuasion every single time." — *People don't need to be convinced to take action if the path to doing so is completely frictionless.*

MYTHS THIS BOOK DESTROYS

- **Myth:** People carefully read and evaluate every option on a screen before making a decision. → **Reality:** People satisfice, grabbing the first plausible option that moves them closer to their goal.
- **Myth:** Clever branding and unique navigation make an experience memorable and engaging. → **Reality:** Cleverness creates confusion and cognitive fatigue, driving users away in frustration.
- **Myth:** Designers can accurately predict user behavior through intuition and internal logic. → **Reality:** Creators are cursed by their own knowledge and must rely on direct observation of real users.
- **Myth:** More features and information options make a product more valuable to the user. → **Reality:** Excess options paralyze decision-making and diminish the perceived value of the core service.

30-DAY ACTION PLAN

- Week 1: Audit your primary digital touchpoint (website, app, or portfolio dashboard) and list every point of friction, jargon, or unnecessary text.
- Week 2: Rewrite all navigation labels and call-to-action buttons using plain, unmistakable language, destroying every hidden "question mark."

- Week 3: Establish a strict visual hierarchy by resizing and repositioning elements so the single most important action stands out instantly.
- Week 4: Recruit three people outside your industry to attempt a core task on your platform while you silently observe without helping.

WHO SHOULD READ SEE THIS

Founders, creators, designers, and wealth-builders who want to scale their impact by removing friction from their offerings. The outcome is a profound shift toward radical simplicity, resulting in higher conversion, deeper trust, and effortless customer adoption.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Where in my digital presence am I forcing people to think when they should just be acting?
- What industry jargon am I clinging to out of a desire to sound sophisticated rather than clear?
- Am I designing for how I **want** users to behave, or for how they **actually** behave in reality?
- What is one unnecessary feature or paragraph I can delete today to make the core message undeniable?

FINAL WORD

True wealth creation—whether in digital products, investing, or personal finance—is the ultimate elimination of friction. When you stop making people think, hesitate, or decode your intentions, you unlock the purest form of leverage: an effortless path from human desire to realized value.